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Sociology and Social Change

Week 8 Wednesday — Perspectives, socialization, community, and place

NRES 315: Human Dimensions of Fish and Wildlife Management

Last updated: 2026-10-06

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Monday gave us the fundamentals

Structure and agency. Social facts. Troubles and issues. Social construction. Social order and social change.

Today: three **perspectives** that ask different questions of the same problem, and the **core concepts** that explain how a person comes to participate at all.

Source: Chapter 9, §§9.4–9.6

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Today's question

Three sociologists look at the same declining participation. What does each one ask?

Source: Chapter 9, §9.4 and Table 9.1

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What you should be able to do

By the end of today, you should be able to:

- distinguish **functionalism**, **conflict**, and **symbolic interactionism**;
- explain **roles** and **identities** as socially constructed;
- explain **socialization** through agent, target, and context; and
- use **community** and **stratification** to say who is served and who is not.

Source: Chapter 9, §§9.4–9.6.4

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Three perspectives

Functionalism · Conflict · Symbolic interactionism

Source: Chapter 9, §9.4 and Table 9.1

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What each one asks

Perspective	View of society	Question
Functionalism	Interdependent institutions maintaining the whole	How do the parts relate and produce this outcome?
Conflict	Competition for resources and power; winners and losers	Who wins, who loses, and what sustains that pattern?
Symbolic interactionism	Meaning negotiated through everyday interaction	How do people construct meaning through interaction?

Source: Chapter 9, §9.4 and Table 9.1

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Roles and identities

Roles are social positions carrying expectations for behavior. **Identity** is the meaning a person attaches to themselves based on how they understand and prioritize those roles.

- Most of us expect to occupy the role of "parent." Far fewer occupy "angler," "hunter," "birdwatcher," or "falconer."
- The meanings and expectations of a prominent role are more widely shared than those of an uncommon one.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.6.1

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Socialization

How people learn the beliefs, values, norms, and behaviors of their culture.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.6.2

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Agent, target, context

- **Agent** — the person or institution doing the socializing.
- **Target** — the person being socialized.
- **Context** — the setting in which it happens.

Primary socialization happens through parents in childhood. **Secondary socialization** happens through peers, teachers, extended family, media, and institutions.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.6.2 and Box 9.2

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Box 9.2 — what actually predicts participation

National survey data on three variables: gender, rural upbringing, and whether the respondent's father hunted.

- 82% of males with a hunting father had tried hunting — and rural versus urban upbringing made **no difference** (81% vs. 83%).
- For females with a hunting father, the effect was modest: 27%.
- For females **without** a hunting father: 6%, with rural upbringing making no difference.

The presence of a hunting agent in the household mattered more than the rural or urban context in which socialization took place.

Source: Chapter 9, Box 9.2

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When does rural upbringing matter?

Exactly one case: **males who grew up rural without hunting fathers** were far more likely to have tried hunting (59%) than urban males without hunting fathers (34%).

Rural upbringing fosters participation mainly by **standing in for absent primary agents** — other family, friends, or institutions step in where the behavior is widely seen as normative.

Source: Chapter 9, Box 9.2

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Socialization can also exclude

Carini and Weber examined how angling magazines socialize women into the sport. They found women were:

- underrepresented relative to their actual participation;
- depicted in stereotypical roles;
- usually accompanied by men; and
- overtly sexualized.

When images reinforce a male-centric social space, people may not see themselves as suitable members of the group.

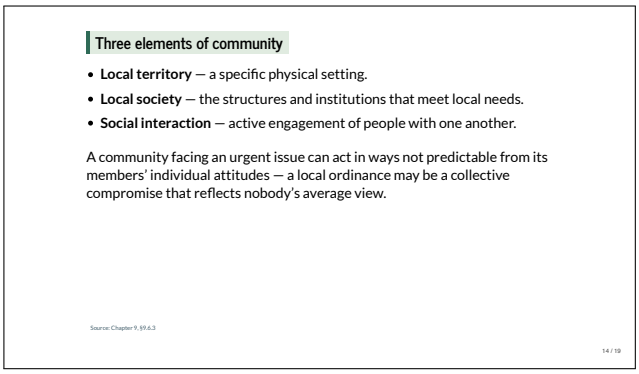
Source: Chapter 9, §9.6.2

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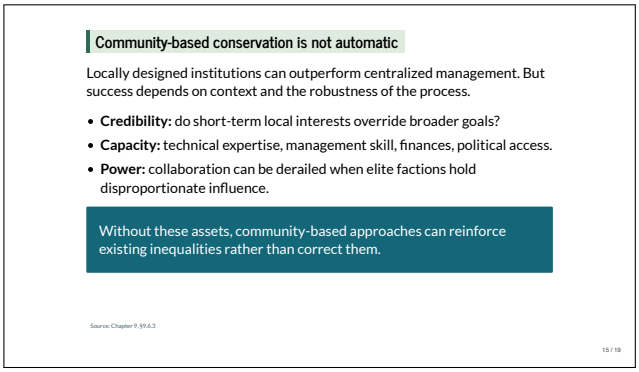
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Stratification and inequality

Stratification: the processes allocating resources and opportunities by hierarchical ranking or socially agreed criteria. **Inequality:** the uneven or unfair distribution that results.

- The cost of equipment, transportation, and access can become prohibitive.
- Agencies risk losing large segments of their user base who can no longer afford to participate.
- Public trust thinking holds that wildlife is not owned by any group but held for the public benefit — which makes equity a trust obligation, not a preference.

Source: Chapter 9, §9.6.4

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Pair rehearsal: name the perspective

With a partner, name the perspective behind each claim:

1. "The walk-in program held the access system together; what changed when it shrank?"
2. "How do rising nonresident leases and declining resident access reveal unequal opportunities?"
3. "'Heritage' means something different now than it did when my father said it."

Source: Chapter 9, §9.4

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Friday

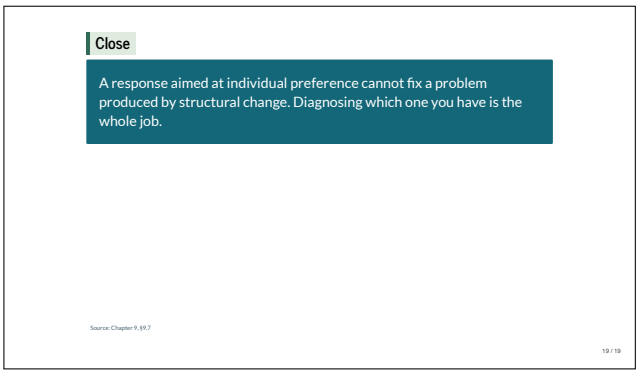
Read the **Week 08 Case Brief: Who Still Hunts Cedar County?** before class. It supplies the case facts; Chapter 9 supplies the concepts.

Licenses down 44% in twenty years. County population nearly flat. Farm operations down from 1,290 to 610. Posted acres up from 61,000 to 219,000.

Source: Chapter 9, §§9.3–9.6

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Close
A response aimed at individual preference cannot fix a problem produced by structural change. Diagnosing which one you have is the whole job.
Source: Chapter 9, §9.7
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